

and hip. That aside, the Candy sports all the hardware under its small hood to seriously vie for your hard earned cash. What we really loved was the option for changing country code that was available in the menu system—boon for playing DVD movies manufactured for playback in a different region. Also available, and easily accessible on the brilliant menu system were a lot of settings that are sometimes missing from such player setup menus like the ability to set and adjust Luma, Gamma, Saturation, Dolby compatibility settings, and even the filtering frequency for sound, individual channel volume adjust and channel delay. The Candy's remote works at very wide angles, and functioned flawlessly at a range of 12 feet, which is more than we

can say for some other players. Another nifty feature is noticeable while skipping chapters in a DVD—the Candy displays the total amount of time elapsed and the total duration of the video so you have an additional indicator—a very small boon, but a plus nonetheless.

With very clear DVD playback, no blurriness and distortion noticeable (other than what is normal for viewing DVD content on a large widescreen LCD) the Candy scores big time as a DVD player. VCD quality is about as good as a 352x240 pixel video can look on a 1366x768 resolution screen. The Candy passed our music tests without any hiccups, and without discernable issues. Onida gets their picture quality spot-on with the Candy, and our high-resolution

images looked good with acceptable pixelation. After such a good showing on the performance figures we'd have loved to see some more connectivity options like a VGA / DVI connect or even USB—a big plus for those who want to play movies off their portable hard drives and thumb drives. With a six-month warranty, we figured Onida has been a bit stingy—especially at a price tag of Rs 3,400—not expensive for the performance on demand—but we wish it had a one-year warranty. Also, this player will not look at home in a suavely designed living room—it's got too much attitude, and it shows.

Intex's N-20VK was one of the plain-jane players—just a cool blue LED that illuminates the drive tray which is made of a translucent fibre based compound. We're thoroughly tired of the blue lights on PC cabinets, notebooks, external hard drives and now DVD players, and we're hoping some vendors are reading this! The Intex N-20VK sports a good finish and acceptable build quality—no complaints here. The ¼-inch jack means you can sing along with your favourite MP3s—a neat plus, considering this player is no slouch with MP3s. The N-20VK didn't do badly at DVDs and we figured that while we'd seen better, we certainly hadn't seen worse. However, we noticed the this player just lagging behind in some of the tests, and this added up when we looked at the price tag—just Rs 2,800—a lot of player for the price, to be sure, but definitely not the best performance out there. That said, the N-20VK has one terrific plus—a VGA port, meaning you can connect this to your PC monitor as well.

Moser Baer had a trio of players in this test and by far the most striking player was the Black Panther—first of all it's half the width of a regular DVD player, which may or may not be attractive—it does make the player look a little bulky from the front. To further enhance this effect, Moser Baer has provided this player with high foot pegs—a real eyesore considering the sleek and wide look is in—is different bad? You decide. The Black Panther played back DVDs

of any region somewhat like the Onida Candy, but the settings were visible, not changeable. The pathetic remote control unit seemed to have a problem at a distance of more than five feet, and within this distance, even slight angles will obstruct functionality. Other than that, we had no complaints whatsoever—the Black Panther really struts its stuff when it comes to any kind of video playback—all our VCD, DVD and DivX tests went off smoothly and without a hitch, and with good visual quality, minimal pixelation and good contrast. A good player, compact and feature rich, along with great performance—at a price of Rs 2,990, the Black Panther seems to have clawed all the good points into its kitty, it's the second best performer too. Just make sure to look before you leap...er...buy, because the squat, burly look may not appeal.

The other two Moser Baer players—the MBI 838 and the MB-6988S were very different lookers, the MB-6988S looks slim at first glance, but the bottom part of the body protrudes and so do the foot pegs, spoiling this effect. Luckily it won't look so bad when placed on a flat surface, especially one that's below eye level. The MBI 838 is slimmer, but both have equally tacky buttons that are hard to press, a shame, this, and annoying too. Once again, we had a few remote interface issues with these two, but the Black Panther has to take the cake in this regard. The front LCD display on the MB-6988S is bright and very readable but looks a little garish after some time, moreover it doesn't exude that quality look that the displays on the Samsung and Philips models have. Both these models have USB ports—a real boon when you have all your DivX titles dumped on a 2.5 inch external drive. Even USB drives can be used, although if the drive is too slow, the movie will lag. In fact, any video files VOB (DVD), DAT (VCD), AVI and even MPEG4 can be kept on a thumb drive / external hard drive and watched at your convenience—very nifty and ultra utilitarian. The MB-6988S also supports memory cards like SD

/ MMC / MS so you can simply pop out your digital camera's memory card, slot it into this player and enjoy your creations immediately. Of the two, the cheaper (Rs 2,990) MB-6988S impressed us marginally more in a few of the video tests, in other areas we'll call it a draw. Overall, at the same price as the smaller and better performing Black Panther, the MB-6988S doesn't make much sense to purchase, unless the lure of a memory card reader and USB port attract you.

Besides the excellent Candy, Onida had three other models, the DFX-5957, DFX-5988 and the DFX-5985 priced at Rs 3,100, 3,300 and 3,000 respectively. So the Candy is the most expensive model amongst the foursome and as our performance tests showed, by far the most suited for a quality home entertain-



Intex N20VK

ment system. All three players sported a sleek look; no ugly protrusions (read foot pegs), and while the DFX-5988 was the best looking, with a steel silver / dark grey body, all three boasted of similar features. We were surprised to see the connectivity options—nothing extra it seems Onida meant for these to be plain vanilla DVD players. After the excellent candy we'd partaken in earlier, this we just couldn't swallow, no matter

LG DP271D—No Idiot Box, This

After last month's PMP test we thought we'd seen it all as far as portable multimedia went. How wrong we were! Enter this little box. The DP271D is a compact DVD player, small and very cute-looking with the same piano-white finish on its lid that some of LG's XNote laptops have. In fact the entire device looks like a miniature laptop. It's got an eight-inch LCD screen that swivels much like a tablet PC. Stereo speakers provided on the lid are quite powerful but the housing does take up precious screen space (we figure LG lost an inch in screen size with a wide bezel and large speaker vents). There are two powerful headphone jacks—cosy! The build quality and fit is very good, no squeaks or loose joints, although the buttons feel a little hard, especially the four way navigation button. The menu is very linear, well laid out and intuitive, and rather feature rich. There's a USB port provided—useful for playing movies off a removable drive, while an AV out ensures you can plug this in to a larger screen. The DP271D has a flip type DVD flap that is worked by a robust spring which we feel will bear the rigours of daily use well. Juice is provided courtesy a 2500 mAh clip on battery pack (much like a laptop), and our tests reveal battery life is good for two DVD movies of 105 minutes each—impressive.

Although the LCD doesn't look a very quality unit (cost cutting we fear) it seems to do a fair if not great job. Our VCD, DVD and DivX tests found the DP271D a little shy on the full gamut of colours, we conclude the panel is a six-bit TN (Twisted Nematic) type. Other than that, contrast seems OK, although a little smattering of



colour was noticeable on darker movies like *Underworld*. DVDs like *Transformers* looked very good, and it was easy to tilt the screen to orient the player any way to suit our convenience. The screen orientation can also be changed.

Music quality was pretty good, and the volume level surprisingly good—no PMP can come close to this on speaker volume, the earphone jacks are also adequately powered for most low-impedance headphones / earplugs. For an MRP of Rs 8,490 the DP271D is a good bargain, add to that the fact that you could probably shave off a thousand bucks or so (actual street prices will be lower), and this is a good buy. But it's not a device for everyone. If you have a PMP and are happy with it, forget this. The hassle of carrying optical media with you will mean this isn't suitable for short journeys like bus and local rides. However, if you're going for a weeklong tour, and want to chill in your hotel room and watch a movie before getting some shut-eye, this may be just up your alley.

Moser Baer MBI AV 780—Just Pop In A DVD

We have reviewed complete entertainment systems before. Such systems are tailored for people who can't be hassled with component synergy but just want something that is built to perform perfectly together. The MBI AV 780 is an inexpensive attempt at the same—a DVD player plus 5.1 surround speakers bundled into one. The DVD player is the largest amongst all our test candidates, courtesy the inbuilt amplifier. Nevertheless, it's a solid unit that exudes build quality, and has an attractive front, that looks very busy with quite a few buttons and a knob, and a lot of small print advertising its features. The speakers follow the same grey / black colour tone of the player, and the black mesh grilles on the satellites looks downright classy. The subwoofer felt a little too light to be really effective, it also looks like it has a rather small driver (four inches). The rear speaker cables are long enough for a small hall, but if your player is around 20 feet away from each speaker you're going to have problems. With auxiliary RCA 5.1 outs and the 6 channel clip type connects for its own speakers, audio connectivity is taken care

of. Optical and coaxial outputs are also provided. S-Video, Component and Composite outs should handle all your video needs (no HDMI here). There's also a jack for an FM radio antenna, and with MW support added, this player is a full-fledged radio. Once again the remote unit although well built and with soft buttons just refused to work unless operated slap bang in front of the player—ridiculous and a very irritating problem, especially for couch lovers.

On the performance front, there wasn't anything to complain about in the way of video quality and the MBI AV 780 proves that price and performance can coexist peacefully. The audio was somewhat of an issue with the underpowered subwoofer, although the satellites are powerful and movies feel really good, they aren't for music where their tendency to be piercingly bright is immediately apparent. If its movies you want, the audio will satisfy you, we only wish for more power in the lower frequencies. Issues aside, what we have here is quite simply excellent value for money (Rs 7,490)—a fully ready home theatre. All you need is a large screen to go with it. If you are looking for a good DVD player and 5.1 surround speakers, why not kill two birds with one stone?

